

AIXelerate Youth Safety & Safeguarding Policy

Organization: AIXelerate Challenge

Policy Owner: AIXelerate Leadership and Board

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1. Introduction

AIXelerate is a student-led organization dedicated to giving young people the knowledge, resources, community, and platform to turn ideas into meaningful solutions with artificial intelligence.

AIXelerate organizes and supports activities including AI competitions, build events, workshops, mentorship, presentations, online communities, and other educational opportunities for young people.

Because many AIXelerate participants are under 18, protecting their safety and well-being is a fundamental responsibility of the organization.

AIXelerate is committed to creating an environment where every participant can learn, build, collaborate, and participate without experiencing abuse, exploitation, harassment, discrimination, bullying, or other inappropriate conduct.

We recognize that safeguarding applies not only to physical events, but also to online spaces, communications, mentorship relationships, social media, and other environments connected to AIXelerate.

AIXelerate will take reasonable steps to identify and reduce risks, establish appropriate boundaries, respond to concerns, and ensure that safeguarding concerns are directed to the appropriate adults and authorities when necessary.

This policy is intended to work alongside the requirements and policies of AIXelerate's fiscal sponsor, Hack Club, and applicable law.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to establish clear standards for protecting children and young people who participate in AIXelerate programs and activities.

This policy explains:

- How AIXelerate works to prevent harm to participants.
- Expected behavior for organizers, mentors, volunteers, judges, speakers, sponsors, and other adults interacting with participants.
- How safeguarding concerns should be recognized and reported.
- Who is responsible for responding to safeguarding concerns.
- How AIXelerate handles participant privacy and personal information.
- Expectations for online communication and communities.
- How AIXelerate works with parents, guardians, schools, venues, and its fiscal sponsor when appropriate.

AIXelerate recognizes that no policy can eliminate every possible risk. Safeguarding therefore requires ongoing attention, responsible decision-making, and a willingness to act when something appears unsafe or inappropriate.

3. Who This Policy Protects

For the purposes of this policy, a **child or minor** is a person under 18 years of age.

This policy applies to:

- Students and participants under 18.
- AIXelerate organizers and volunteers.
- Mentors and judges.
- Speakers and workshop leaders.
- Event staff and contractors.
- Sponsors and partners when interacting with AIXelerate participants.
- Adults participating in AIXelerate online communities or programs.
- Any other person acting on behalf of or representing AIXelerate.

AIXelerate will take safeguarding concerns seriously even when the concern involves conduct that occurs outside an AIXelerate event, if the organization becomes aware of a situation that may place a participant at risk.

4. Our Safeguarding Principles

AIXelerate follows these principles:

Safety first

The safety and well-being of young participants takes priority over an event, competition, project, relationship, or organizational interest.

Respect

Every participant should be treated with dignity and respect regardless of background, identity, ability, experience level, or role within an event.

Appropriate boundaries

Adults representing AIXelerate must maintain appropriate professional boundaries with minors.

Speak up

A person does not need to be certain that abuse or inappropriate conduct has occurred before raising a safeguarding concern.

Need-to-know confidentiality

Safeguarding information should only be shared with people who need the information to respond appropriately, subject to legal and safety requirements.

Youth voice

AIXelerate values young people's perspectives and encourages participants to raise concerns about their experiences and safety.

Accountability

AIXelerate organizers and representatives are responsible for following this policy and reporting concerns appropriately.

5. Types of Harm and Safeguarding Concerns

AIXelerate expects organizers and adult representatives to remain alert to possible signs of:

- Physical abuse.
- Emotional or psychological abuse.
- Sexual abuse or exploitation.
- Neglect or inadequate supervision.
- Bullying and harassment.
- Cyberbullying.
- Discrimination.
- Grooming or inappropriate relationship-building.
- Inappropriate communication between adults and minors.
- Unsafe or exploitative use of photographs, videos, or other participant information.
- Other conduct that places a minor at unreasonable risk of harm.

A concern does not need to meet a particular definition or threshold before it can be reported internally.

6. Responsibilities of AIXelerate Representatives

Anyone representing AIXelerate is expected to:

- Read and follow this policy and the AIXelerate Code of Conduct.
- Treat participants respectfully.
- Maintain appropriate boundaries with minors.
- Follow event supervision and safety procedures.
- Report safeguarding concerns promptly.
- Protect participant information.
- Avoid placing themselves or participants in unnecessarily vulnerable situations.
- Cooperate with appropriate safeguarding processes.
- Follow any additional requirements established by AIXelerate's fiscal sponsor, event venue, school, or other responsible organization.

AIXelerate representatives should not attempt to independently investigate suspected abuse or determine whether a report is legally substantiated.

7. Safeguarding Contact

AIXelerate will designate at least one responsible adult safeguarding contact, and preferably a safeguarding team, to receive and coordinate responses to safeguarding concerns.

Primary Safeguarding Contact:

Name: [INSERT NAME]

Role: [INSERT ROLE]

Email: [INSERT EMAIL]

Phone: [INSERT PHONE, IF APPROPRIATE]

Secondary Safeguarding Contact:

Name: [INSERT NAME]

Role: [INSERT ROLE]

Email: [INSERT EMAIL]

Phone: [INSERT PHONE, IF APPROPRIATE]

AIXelerate should confirm these contacts with its fiscal sponsor before publishing this policy.

Participants, parents/guardians, volunteers, mentors, and other community members may raise concerns with the designated safeguarding contact.

People do not need to be certain that abuse or inappropriate conduct occurred before raising a concern.

8. Responding to a Safeguarding Concern

If someone tells an AIXelerate representative about a safeguarding concern:

Listen

Listen calmly and take the concern seriously.

Do not investigate

Do not attempt to conduct an investigation, confront the person accused, or ask extensive or leading questions.

Do not promise secrecy

AIXelerate representatives should not promise that information will remain completely confidential. Explain that information may need to be shared with appropriate adults or authorities to protect someone from harm.

Record

Record the relevant facts as accurately as possible, including what was observed or reported and when it occurred.

Report

Pass the concern to the designated AIXelerate safeguarding contact as soon as possible.

Escalate when necessary

The safeguarding contact will determine the appropriate next steps, including whether the matter should be referred to a parent/guardian, fiscal sponsor, school, venue, child-protection authority, law enforcement, or another appropriate professional.

If there is an immediate danger to a participant, emergency services should be contacted as appropriate.

9. Online Communities and Communication

AIXelerate may use online platforms such as Discord, email, event-management systems, collaboration tools, and social media.

Because online communication can create additional safeguarding risks, AIXelerate representatives should:

- Use official AIXelerate channels when communicating with participants whenever practical.
- Maintain professional boundaries in direct messages and other communications.
- Avoid unnecessary private communication between an adult representative and a minor.
- Never request or encourage inappropriate personal information, images, or communications from participants.

- Never use AIXelerate's online communities to engage in harassment, sexualized communication, grooming, or other inappropriate behavior.
- Escalate concerning messages or behavior through the safeguarding process.

AIXelerate should establish specific moderation procedures for any Discord or other online community before opening it to minors.

10. Events and In-Person Activities

For AIXelerate events, organizers should take reasonable steps to ensure:

- Participants know who the responsible adults are.
- Appropriate adult supervision is present.
- Event spaces are appropriate for minors.
- Emergency procedures are communicated to responsible staff.
- Participants know how to report a concern.
- Organizers know how to contact emergency services and event/venue personnel.
- Adult representatives avoid unnecessarily being alone with a minor.
- Mentors and volunteers understand the applicable Code of Conduct.
- Any venue-specific safety requirements are followed.

Where AIXelerate operates within a school, university, company, or other host organization, AIXelerate will follow applicable safeguarding and safety requirements established by that organization.

11. Mentors, Judges, Speakers, and Volunteers

Adults participating in AIXelerate programs in a position of trust or authority over minors are expected to:

- Follow the AIXelerate Code of Conduct.
- Maintain appropriate professional boundaries.
- Avoid inappropriate private relationships with participants.
- Avoid unnecessary one-on-one situations with minors.
- Communicate through appropriate channels.
- Never engage in sexualized or otherwise inappropriate communication with participants.

- Report safeguarding concerns.

Where appropriate and feasible, AIXelerate and/or its fiscal sponsor will establish screening, background-check, training, or other requirements for adults who have significant or repeated contact with minors.

The specific requirements for screening and background checks should be established in coordination with Hack Club and any host organization rather than assumed by this policy.

12. Photography, Video, and Social Media

AIXelerate may document events for educational, promotional, and community purposes.

AIXelerate will:

- Respect applicable consent requirements for photographing or recording minors.
- Avoid publishing content that could reasonably place a participant at risk.
- Avoid sharing unnecessary personal information alongside photographs or videos.
- Not allow AIXelerate representatives to use participant images for personal purposes.
- Follow the requirements of event venues, schools, fiscal sponsors, and applicable law.

Participant and parent/guardian consent requirements should be established for each event where minors may be photographed or recorded.

13. Privacy and Participant Information

AIXelerate will treat participant information responsibly.

Personal information should only be collected when reasonably necessary for activities such as:

- Event registration.
- Emergency contact information.
- Parent/guardian communication.
- Program administration.
- Competition administration.
- Providing event services.
- Meeting legal, venue, or fiscal-sponsor requirements.

Access to sensitive participant information should be limited to people who need it to perform their responsibilities.

AIXelerate representatives must not unnecessarily share participant information with other people, organizations, or online communities.

14. Code of Conduct

All adults representing AIXelerate are expected to:

Always

- Treat participants respectfully.
- Prioritize participant safety and well-being.
- Respect participant boundaries.
- Maintain appropriate professional relationships.
- Respect privacy.
- Follow AIXelerate's safeguarding procedures.
- Take safeguarding concerns seriously.
- Report concerns appropriately.
- Treat participants fairly and without discrimination.
- Set a positive example.

Never

- Use physical punishment or violence.
 - Bully, threaten, humiliate, or harass a participant.
 - Use sexualized language or behavior toward a participant.
 - Engage in a romantic or sexual relationship with a minor.
 - Send or request inappropriate images or messages.
 - Share inappropriate or sexual content with participants.
 - Use participant information for personal purposes.
 - Intentionally place a participant in an unsafe situation.
 - Retaliate against someone for raising a safeguarding concern.
 - Ignore a safeguarding concern because it appears minor or uncertain.
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15. Reporting Concerns

Anyone involved with AIXelerate is encouraged to report concerns about:

- A participant's safety.
- An adult's behavior toward a participant.
- Another participant's behavior.
- Online conduct.
- Bullying or harassment.
- Inappropriate communication.
- Unsafe event conditions.
- Any suspected abuse, exploitation, or neglect.

Reports should be made to the designated safeguarding contact.

AIXelerate Safeguarding Email:

[INSERT EMAIL]

If the situation presents an immediate danger, contact emergency services or the appropriate emergency authority first.

AIXelerate will not retaliate against a person who raises a safeguarding concern in good faith.

16. Handling Reports

AIXelerate will:

1. Take every safeguarding concern seriously.
2. Prioritize the immediate safety of the participant.
3. Document relevant information accurately.
4. Limit information sharing to appropriate people.
5. Avoid conducting investigations beyond the organization's role.
6. Consult its fiscal sponsor and appropriate professionals when necessary.
7. Make referrals to appropriate authorities when required.
8. Consider whether additional safety measures are necessary.
9. Review whether organizational procedures need to change following an incident.

AIXelerate will not attempt to determine guilt or innocence through an informal internal process.

17. Policy Implementation and Review

This policy will be reviewed at least bi-annually and whenever a significant change occurs to AIXelerate's activities, organizational structure, or safeguarding requirements.

AIXelerate will make reasonable efforts to ensure that relevant organizers, volunteers, mentors, and other representatives are aware of the policy.

The policy should be reviewed with AIXelerate's fiscal sponsor and, where applicable, event venues, schools, or other partner organizations.

Any substantial changes to this policy should be communicated to relevant participants, parents/guardians, organizers, and representatives.

Appendix A — AIXelerate Safeguarding Code of Conduct Acknowledgment

I confirm that I have received, read, and understood the AIXelerate Youth Safety & Safeguarding Policy and Code of Conduct.

I understand my responsibility to maintain appropriate boundaries with young participants and to report safeguarding concerns through the appropriate channels.

Name: Vishakh Arumugachamy

Role: Founder

Signature: Vishakh Arumugachamy

Date: 10/3/26

Appendix B — Event Safeguarding Checklist

Before each AIXelerate event, organizers should confirm:

- Responsible adult safeguarding contact identified.
- Emergency contact and emergency procedures confirmed.
- Venue safety requirements reviewed.

- Participant supervision arrangements established.
 - Adult volunteers/mentors understand their responsibilities.
 - Appropriate registration and parent/guardian information collected.
 - Photography/video consent requirements established.
 - Online communication channels moderated appropriately.
 - Participants know how to raise a concern.
 - Relevant fiscal-sponsor requirements have been reviewed.
 - Incident-reporting process is available to organizers.
 - Accessibility and participant support needs have been considered.
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